

to others knowledge that is different from their own. These, according to researchers, are the people you commonly see involved in engineering or populating physics departments. We saw one of them, Dr. John, in [Chapter 9](#).

You can test a child for underdevelopment of the theory of mind using a variant of the “false-belief task.” Two children are introduced. One child puts a toy under the bed and leaves the room. During his absence, the second child—the subject—removes it and hides it in a box. You ask the subject: Where, upon returning to the room, will the other child look for the toy? Those under, say, the age of four (when the theory of mind starts developing), choose the box, while older children correctly say that the other child will look under the bed. At around that age, children start realizing that another person can be deprived of some of the information they have, and can hold beliefs that are different from their own. Now, this test helps detect mild forms of autism: as high as one’s intelligence may be, it can be difficult for many to put themselves in other people’s shoes and imagine the world on the basis of other people’s information. There is actually a name for the condition of a person who can be functional but suffers from a mild form of autism: Asperger syndrome.

The psychologist Simon Baron-Cohen has produced much research distinguishing between polar extremes in people’s temperament with respect to two faculties: ability to systematize, and ability to empathize and understand others. According to his research, purely systematizing persons suffer from a lack of theory of mind; they are drawn to engineering and similar occupations (and when they fail, to, say, mathematical economics); empathizing minds are drawn to more social (or literary) professions. Fat Tony, of course, would fall in the more social category. Males are overrepresented in the systematizing category; females dominate the other extreme.

Note the unsurprising, but very consequential fact that people with Asperger syndrome are highly averse to ambiguity.

Research shows that academics are overrepresented in the systematizing, Black-Swan-blind category; these are the people I called “Locke’s madmen” in [Chapter 17](#). I haven’t seen any formal direct test of Black Swan foolishness and the systematizing mind, except for a calculation George Martin and I made in 1998, in which we found evidence that all the finance and quantitative economics professors from major universities whom we tracked and who got involved in hedge fund trading ended up making bets *against* Black Swans, exposing themselves to blowups. This preference was nonrandom, since between one third and one half of the nonprofessors had that investment style at the time.